in India’s population. On the whole, the first phase of agriculture development programmes and policy (1947–64) was a big disappointment. It did not make India self-sufficient, even for food.

India’s Worst Food Crisis and PL-480

Two years of drought in 1965–67 completely exposed the weaknesses of the agriculture development strategy of the first three Plans.

The year 1965 was disastrous. Foodgrains production fell massively to 72 million tonnes in 1965–66 and 74 million tonnes in 1966–67. Ironically, while India was facing massive food shortages during the 1950s and 1960s, on the other side of the globe, Americans were wallowing in excess production of wheat.

American food aid to India, which later acquired very humiliating overtones, commenced in 1951. American President Harry Truman approved a $2 million wheat loan as part of the India Emergency Food Aid Bill in June 1951. More food aid flowed from America under the Agriculture Trade Development and Assistance Act, passed in 1954, widely known as Public Law 480 or PL-480.

It is estimated that India received total food aid of about 50 million tonnes over a twenty-year period (1951–1971), which was estimated to be worth $10 billion. This was the largest food assistance programme ever undertaken for any country. India stopped accepting food aid from America in the early 1970s. In the fifty years of PL-480 (1954–2004), it is estimated that America provided food aid aggregating $33 billion globally; India received one-third of this.

1965–1990: A Different Food Production Strategy

India changed its foodgrains development strategy fundamentally in the second phase (1965–1990). The new strategy was based on three principal